

Board 1

South Deals

None Vul

♠ Q 10 5 4
 ♥ J 8 3
 ♦ 10 9 3
 ♣ A 8 5

♠ K 8 3 2
 ♥ Q 10 9 5 2
 ♦ K 7
 ♣ 6 2



♠ J 9 6
 ♥ A 7
 ♦ A 6 5 2
 ♣ J 10 9 4

♠ A 7
 ♥ K 6 4
 ♦ Q J 8 4
 ♣ K Q 7 3

West	North	East	South
			1NT
Pass	2♣	Pass	2♦
Pass	2♥	Pass	3♥
All Pass			
3♥ by North			

North plays 3♥. East leads the ♣J.

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Losers: ♠ 2 : ♥ 2 : ♦ 1 : ♣ 1 : Total = 6

You may be able to ruff 1 ♠ in dummy, and discard another on a long ♦. And you hope to keep your trump losers to 1.

Start by covering the ♣J to set up a sure ♣ trick. West wins the ♣A and returns a ♣, won by dummy's ♣K. It looks better to start the trumps from your side, so play a ♦ toward your ♦K. East wins and plays a ♣, which you ruff. Now lead a ♥, playing the ♥K if East plays low. Assume this wins the trick. Lead a ♥ back, finessing the ♥9 since you think East must hold the ♥A. He does hold it, and takes it right now. East leads a ♠. You win the ♠A in dummy, play the ♠7 to your ♠K, and ruff a ♠ with dummy's last trump. Now lead dummy's ♦ Q J, discarding a ♠ on the last one. You have only good trumps left.

The play for this hand was not straightforward at all, and might have taken a different path had the West/East cards been arranged differently. However, the general approach of ruffing a ♠ in dummy and setting up the ♦ suit would bring the best result with most arrangements.

Because you have an invitational hand with a 4-card Major (♠s) you use Stayman.

After your 2♣ bid partner says 2♦.

Partner does not have 4 (♠s) so you have no 8-card fit there. However, he might have 3 ♥s, so you now bid 2♥. Partner will understand you are showing a 5-card suit.

Partner bids 3♥.

This could go either way. You started out with 9 points, but perhaps you could revalue your hand upward after you find the fit. The problem with that is those two doubletons are in the long-trump hand, and taking ruffs in the long-trump hand doesn't usually add tricks. You take the conservative route and pass.

Board 3

East Deals

None Vul

♠ K J 7 5 4 2

♥ A 8 4

♦ 7

♣ 8 7 2

♠ 8

♥ Q 7 5 2

♦ A J 8 2

♣ Q 6 5 3



♠ 10 9 3

♥ J 10 6 3

♦ Q 10 9 3

♣ J 4

♠ A Q 6

♥ K 9

♦ K 6 5 4

♣ A K 10 9

West	North	East	South
		Pass	1♦
Pass	1♥	Pass	2NT
Pass	3♦	Pass	3NT
All Pass			

3NT by South

fact that most of your strength is in the black suits should help you decide on 3NT.

You have 19 points, too much for 1NT. With two 4-card minors you should open 1♦, regardless of strength. Partner responds 1♥.

Partner's ♥ bid makes you very happy. It also makes your rebid a snap. With 19 points and a balanced hand you jump to 2NT.

Partner now surprises you a little by saying 3♦.

What is your next bid?

For partner to take you out of Notrump he must have a distributional hand, probably with a singleton or void in one of the black suits. You have to make the choice between passing, bidding 4♦ or 5♦, or bidding 3NT.

While any of those choices might turn out best, the

South plays 3NT. West leads the ♠5. East plays the ♠9.

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Winner count: ♠ 2 : ♥ 0 : ♦ 2 : ♣ 4? : Total = 8?

Those 4 ♣ winners assume a 3-2 split. Since that is going to be the first suit you play you will find out soon enough.

You win the ♠Q. Play the ♣K, then the ♣10 (trying to tempt a cover). Go up with the ♣Q and East follows with the ♣J so you do have 4 ♣ tricks. Take your other two ♣s right now.

You are now at the crossroads. For your ninth trick should you try the ♦ finesse or should you establish a ♥. It's a no-brainer. If you finesse a ♦ and it loses to East's ♦Q a ♠ will come back, knocking out your last stopper. Then, if the ♦s fail to split 3-2 you will be short one winner and it will be too late to set up the ♥. So ignore the finesse and set up a ♥ for your guaranteed nine tricks.

As you can see, with this layout a ♦ finesse would be fatal.

East would win and play a ♠, and whether you ducked this one or not your last stopper would soon be removed. When ♦s failed to split 3-2 you would have been forced to try a ♥. West would win his ♥A and set you with ♠s.

Correctly played you would lead a ♥ honor to establish one trick in the suit and easily make the game with 2 ♠s, 1 ♥, 2 ♦s and 4 ♣s.

Board 5

North Deals

N-S Vul

♠ 10 9 3

♥ 9 2

♦ A Q 10 4

♣ A J 7 3

♠ A K J 8 6 2

♥ K 7 4

♦ 2

♣ K 6 5



♠ 7 5

♥ Q J 10 8 5 3

♦ K J 7

♣ 10 9

♠ Q 4

♥ A 6

♦ 9 8 6 5 3

♣ Q 8 4 2

West

North

East

South

Pass

3♠

Pass

4♠

All Pass

4♠ by North

You must eliminate one loser and the easiest one will be the ♥ which you can ruff in dummy. However, West's ♥9 looks a little ominous, particularly since East apparently has some length in the suit. Presumably you played the ♥A on the first trick. Next lead the ♥6 from dummy, hoping West can't (or doesn't) ruff. He plays the ♥2. Win the ♥K and play your ♥4, ruffing with dummy's ♠Q. West is out of ♥s, but can't over-ruff. Now pull trumps and set up one ♣ trick. You lose 2 ♣s and a ♦, just as expected.

Ruffing with the ♠Q might cost a trick if the ♠s split 4-1 and West did not have a doubleton ♥. But you need to stay flexible and make your decisions based on what you see happening at the table. In this deal, after West signalled high-low in ♥s it was logical to play him for a doubleton.

An easy one. You bid 1♠. Partner responds 1NT.

What is your next bid?

You're going to rebid your 6-card ♠ suit, but how high? The usual guideline is to bid 2♠ with 13-15 points, but jump to 3♠ with 16-18 points. You come in just over the line so you bid 3♠. Partner puts it in game.

North plays 4♠. East leads the ♥Q, West playing ♥9.

North plays 4♠. East leads the ♥Q, West playing ♥9.

Losers: ♠ 0 : ♥ 1 : ♦ 1 : ♣ 2 : Total = 4